Decouple.

MADE 20 OCTOBER 2026

Your guide

Made from your own answers, on your device. Decouple doesn’t keep a copy.

Keep it somewhere private.

CONTENTS

A 10–20 year marriage, children at home, and a lot to work out. *Here's your way through.*

01 Where you are, and what to expect

02 Getting the full picture together

03 The children's arrangements

04 The home, and where you'll live

05 What a fair split might look like

06 Reaching agreement

07 Making it legal, in the right order

08 Looking after yourself

Decouple is not a law firm, and this guide is not legal advice. Figures are rough estimates from the bands you chose, based on the law in England and Wales. If you're worried about your safety, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline free on 0808 2000 247, any time. In an emergency, call 999.

CHAPTER 01

Where you are, and what to expect

WHERE YOU ARE

You've decided. The next job is the picture.

Before anything is split, you both need to know what there is. Starting early takes the heat out of everything that follows.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- The first few months are often the hardest, emotionally and practically.
- From here to a legally binding agreement usually takes 6 to 12 months.
- You don't have to sort everything at once. There is an order, and this guide follows it.

THE WHOLE JOURNEY, IN ORDER

Two things run side by side: the divorce, and the money.

The divorce ends the marriage. The money is settled separately, by a financial order. Many people don't realise they're different.

✓ **Get support, and get steady**
Now
Talk to people you trust. Cover the basics: money for the next few months, and somewhere to live.

02 **Get the financial picture together** You are here
Weeks 1 to 8
You each list everything you own, owe and earn, with evidence. Usually on a Form E.

03 **Agree arrangements for the children**
Alongside
Where they live and how they spend time with you both. Often written as a parenting plan.

04 **Agree how to split everything**
Months 2 to 6
Between yourselves, in mediation, or through solicitors. Most couples use mediation.

05 **Apply for the divorce**
Any time
Online, on your own or together. The court fee is about £600. It can run alongside the steps above.

06 **Conditional order**
At least 20 weeks after applying
Confirms you're entitled to divorce. Your consent order can go to the court after this.

07 **Make the agreement legally binding**
After the conditional order
A consent order goes to the court with a short summary form (D81). A judge checks it's fair.

08 **Final order**
At least 6 weeks after the conditional order
Ends the marriage. Wait until the financial order is approved.

CHAPTER 02

Getting the full picture together

THE FINANCIAL PICTURE

You'll both need to show everything, with evidence.

Courts call this full and frank disclosure. If you use a mediator or solicitor, they'll usually ask you each to fill in a **Form E**: a long financial statement with documents attached. Your partner will need to complete one too, and you'll swap them.

Form E	Bank statements	Typical time
About 28 pages	**12 months**	**4 to 8 weeks**
each of you	every account	to gather it all

WHAT YOU'LL NEED, FROM WHAT YOU TOLD US

– **Bank statements** — Both
12 months, for every account in your name, or joint.

– **Payslips and your P60** — Both
Your last three payslips and latest P60.

– **Pension valuations (a CETV for each)** — Both
Ask each provider now. They can take weeks, sometimes months.

– **The home** — Both
A mortgage statement, and two or three estate agent valuations.

– **Debts** — Both
Latest statements for every card, loan and finance agreement.

– **What you each need to live on** — Both
Monthly spending, now and after you separate.

Start with what's easiest. Requesting pension valuations today is the single biggest time-saver.

CHAPTER 03

The children's arrangements

THE CHILDREN

Their arrangements are agreed separately, and child-first.

Courts expect parents to agree where the children live and how they spend time with each of you. Most do it without a court, often in a written parenting plan. Child maintenance is separate again: agree it between you, or use the Child Maintenance Service.

Telling them
If you can, tell them together, with a simple, shared explanation. Keep it age-appropriate, and leave blame out.

Where they live
Starting from what happens now usually works best, then adjust as you go.

Money for them
Child maintenance is worked out from the paying parent's income and how many nights the children stay.

A PARENTING-PLAN STARTER

Alternate weekends + midweek

We've suggested a pattern from where the children live now and their ages. Pick another common arrangement, or tap any night to make it yours.

	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Week 1	Y	Y	P	Y	Y	Y	Y
Week 2	Y	Y	P	Y	P	P	Y

You · 10 nights Your partner · 4 nights 71/29 split 6 handovers a fortnight

How it works

The children live mainly with one of you. The other has every other weekend and one midweek overnight.

Works well when

One of you works long hours or lives a little further away.

Watch out

The midweek night keeps the bond going — protect it.

School runs | Holidays & birthdays | Big decisions | New partners | Moving house

CHAPTER 04

The home, and where you'll live

THE HOME

There are 4 common ways to deal with the home.

There's no single right answer. Most couples look at two or three options side by side before deciding.

01

Sell, and split the proceeds

The cleanest break. You both buy or rent again.

Works when neither of you can afford it alone.

02

One keeps it, and buys the other out

Needs a mortgage in one name, and enough to pay the other's share.

Works when one income can carry the mortgage.

03 · often fits families like yours

One stays until the children are older

The sale is delayed, often until the youngest turns 18. Sometimes called a Mesher order.

Keeps the children's home stable.

04

Transfer it, and balance it elsewhere

One keeps the home, the other takes more of the savings or pensions.

Works when there's enough else to balance it.

WHERE YOU'LL LIVE

Having some idea is a good start.

Start with a real number. A mortgage in principle, or a look at local rents, tells you what's realistic before you negotiate.

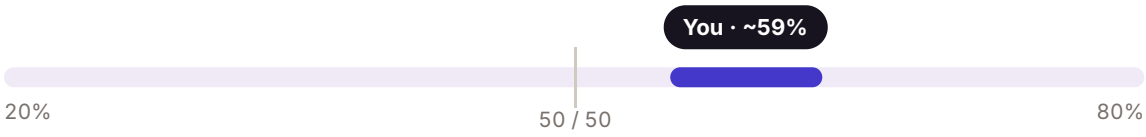
- ✓ Ask two or three local agents for a free valuation.
- ✓ Find out what you could borrow, or rent, on your own.
- ✓ Moving out doesn't give up your rights to the home, but get advice before you go if you can.
- ✓ Think about school runs and the children's routines when you look.

CHAPTER 05

What a fair split might look like

YOUR LIKELY SETTLEMENT RANGE

A court would likely see 55–63% to you as reasonable.



Estimated pot	Your likely share	Pension to balance
£693k	£380k–£435k	Yes
after debts	55–63%	~£100k gap

- The children live mainly with you, so housing them weighs heavily.
- Your partner earns noticeably more, which tilts capital towards you.
- A long marriage — the starting point is an equal split, adjusted for needs.

An indicative range based on what you told us — not legal advice. Exact figures come once accounts are connected.

WHAT A COURT LOOKS AT

It isn't a formula. It's these things, weighed together.

Needs

Especially housing for whoever the children mainly live with.

Income and earning power

Now, and realistically in the future.

Length of the marriage

Longer marriages usually start from an equal split.

Contributions

Money in, and caring for the home and children, count equally.

Pensions

Built up during the marriage, and usually shared.

Age, health and standard of living

What life looked like together, and what's realistic now.

THINGS TO WATCH

Don't leave the pensions out

Pensions are the most overlooked asset in DIY settlements — and often the most valuable. Get a valuation (a CETV) for each one.

Get the home valued early

Your biggest asset shouldn't run on a guess. Three agent valuations settle most disputes before they start.

Joint debts stay joint

Lenders can chase either of you for joint debts until they're cleared or moved into one name.

CHAPTER 06

Reaching agreement

REACHING AGREEMENT

Most couples agree in mediation. Some use solicitors. Few end up in court.

When things are tense, a neutral person in the room keeps conversations on track.

	Typical cost	Typical time
Between yourselves Talk it through and write down what you agree. It still needs making legal.	Free	Weeks
Mediation Most common A neutral mediator helps you both reach agreement. A first meeting (a MIAM) is usually needed before going to court.	Often £100 to £200 an hour each	2 to 3 months, 3 to 5 sessions
Solicitors Each of you has a solicitor, who negotiates on your behalf.	Often a few thousand pounds each	6 to 12 months
Arbitration A private, qualified decision-maker settles it. Faster than court, and binding.	Several thousand pounds	2 to 4 months
Court A judge decides, if you can't agree any other way.	Often over £10,000 each	12 to 18 months or more

Typical figures for England and Wales, October 2026. Mediation vouchers may help with costs if you have children.

WHAT YOUR PARTNER MAY SAY

Going in prepared makes the hard conversations shorter.

"It should be 50/50."

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Your partner may start from an even split. The answer: equal is the starting point, but needs — especially the children's housing — can move it.

"Let's just sell the house."

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Selling gives your partner cash now. Be ready to show whether you can keep the home, or what a suitable home nearby would cost.

"My pension is mine."

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Pensions built during the marriage are usually shared. A pension sharing order can balance it without selling anything.

CHAPTER 07

Making it legal, in the right order

MAKING IT LEGAL

An agreement only becomes binding once a judge approves it.

This is done with a consent order: your agreement written in legal terms, sent to the court with a short summary form called a D81. A judge reviews it to check it's fair, usually without either of you attending.

01 — Apply for the divorce
Week 0
Online, alone or jointly.

02 — Conditional order
Week 20+
Apply once the 20 weeks are up.

03 — Send the consent order
After that
With a D81 summary form.

04 — A judge approves it
Weeks to months
Usually on paper, no hearing.

05 — Final order
Last
Only once the money is approved.

Divorce application
About £600
court fee, paid once

Consent order
About £60
court fee

Shortest timetable
6 to 7 months
set by the divorce

Don't finalise the divorce too early

Applying for the final order before the financial order is approved can cost you pension and inheritance rights.

It doesn't have to be a solicitor

You can write and file a consent order yourselves. Many people still pay for a check, so the wording holds up.

CHAPTER 08

Looking after yourself

LOOKING AFTER YOURSELF

Up and down is completely normal.

Expect good days and hard ones, sometimes in the same hour. Sleep, food and someone to talk to matter more than any form.

You have friends and family around you. Lean on them, and tell them what would actually help.

WHAT TO DO THIS WEEK

Small, practical steps that make everything after them easier.

1. **Start a list of everything you own and owe**
   Rough figures are fine. You'll firm them up later.
2. **Ask for your pension valuations**
   Request a CETV from each provider. It's usually free once a year.
3. **Plan what you'll tell the children**
   Together, if you can.

PRACTICAL THINGS TO SORT, WHEN YOU'RE READY

- ✓ **Bills, and who pays.** Write down who covers what for now, so nothing is missed.
- ✓ **Where post goes.** Set up redirection if one of you has moved.
- ✓ **Updating your will.** Separation doesn't cancel a will. Your ex could still inherit.
- ✓ **Pension and insurance beneficiaries.** Check who's named on each policy and pension.
- ✓ **Telling family and friends.** Decide together, if you can, what you'll say.
- ✓ **Telling school or the GP.** So they can look out for the children, and for you.

FREE, TRUSTED SUPPORT

Samaritans
116 123, free, any time

National Domestic Abuse Helpline
0808 2000 247, free, any time

MoneyHelper
Free, impartial guides on money and separation

Citizens Advice
Free advice on housing, benefits and debt

Family Mediation Council
Find an accredited mediator near you

Cafcass
A free parenting plan for the children's arrangements